

## IROKO-MED-BOT

Nigeria's health system, including its mental health provision, has long been underfunded. Between 2015 and 2025, Nigeria has consistently spent less than **5% of its budget on healthcare**. It is not known how many people in Nigeria live with mental health conditions but, with **only 262 psychiatrists** in a country of 240 million people, most do not get adequate treatment. For example Schizophrenia, a severe, chronic mental health disorder affecting approximately 24 million people worldwide (about 1 in 300 people globally) Most of the affected people end up having Stigma, delayed diagnosis (average onset is late teens to early 30s), and inconsistent access to treatment and not even aware of a possibility of their symptoms. Early intervention is critical. Longer untreated psychosis correlates with worse long term outcomes. still More than **90% of Nigerians have no health insurance**, and now face uncertainty over access to services and feelings of helplessness over rising costs.

We propose Iroko-Med-Bot, a medical chatbot that serves as a source of Medical information and advice on Mental health to create awareness of certain mental illness and enlighten it's users on the symptoms, propose drug free remedies that can ease the ailment and also propose the need to see a medical professional if the need arises.

We understand that Large Language Models (LLMs) are "black boxes" **that clinicians don't trust**. Research shows they **agree with harmful suggestions** in nearly a third of mental health crises and misinterpret cultural expressions of distress as "delusions".

We intend to develop a Small Language Models (SLMs) that is trained particularly on Mental Health data, and will be robust to cultural expressions that will be suitable to the Nigerian Demographics and uses state of the art Agentic AI techniques that ensures the model, serves as a triage tool, is stigma free, avoids agreeing with harmful suggestions, gives factual information and provides a source to the information

Iroko-Med-bot, is a SLM that is a stigma free first line information and triage tool for individuals and Families concerned about Mental Health in Nigeria.